

Surprise-inactive receiver unders

One NFL betting edge that survived a season-length search through game lines, totals, quarter and half markets, player-prop models and prediction-market liquidity.

The rule

About **90 minutes before kickoff**, NFL teams publish their inactive lists.

- 1 Trigger:** a WR, TE or RB is **inactive** but was **not listed Out or Doubtful** on that week's final injury report, and he had **≥ 10% of his team's targets** over his previous 3 games.
- 2 Bet:** the **under** on each remaining teammate's **receptions** and **receiving yards**.
- 3 Where:**
 - **Novig** first. Take the listed under at the consensus line.
 - **Kalshi** if Novig doesn't list the prop. Buy NO on the ladder contract that matches the line ("5+ receptions" for under 4.5), **only when the spread is ≤ 4¢**. Otherwise rest a NO bid at the mid until kickoff. Never take a wide Kalshi book: the spread eats the whole edge.
- 4 Stake:** flat and small. About 1–2 triggers a week, 15–20 bets.

Why it works

When a role player is a surprise scratch, books and bettors push his teammates' receiving lines up to absorb the freed targets, and they push them too far. The freed volume spreads across more players and a less efficient offense than the lines assume. The market prices absences it has known about for days correctly (no edge there). The overreaction is specific to **late, surprise** scratches, and it grows with the size of the vacated role.

Evidence

Backtest, 2023–2026

All triggers use only information available before kickoff: the scratched player's usage from earlier games, Friday's report and game-day inactives. Graded at the closing line, with standard errors clustered by team-game.

	Result
Qualifying team-games	217
Teammates' receiving overs vs. de-vigged fair price	43.9% vs 49.7%
Edge beyond the normal receiving under lean	−4.0 pts, $t = -2.6$
ROI at the best sportsbook price	+5.4% to +7.5% (95% CI on the broad prop set: +0.2% to +10.6%)
ROI at Novig/ProphetX prices	+10.2% (584 bets)
ROI at Novig only, 2025 (Novig listed 87.5% of qualifying props)	+11.5% (70 team-games). Novig baseline for all receiving unders: +0.9%
By season, best book	2023 +0.7%, 2024 +8.5%, 2025 +13.1%
Dose-response (vacated target share 10–18% / 18–30% / 30%+)	−3.3 / −9.6 / −7.9 pts vs. fair
Kalshi (2025–26, priced 1 min after inactives)	Taking any ask −1.1%. Spread ≤ 4¢ +13.1% (105 contracts). At the mid +11.6%
Probability the true ROI > 0 (bootstrap)	~98%

Live paper test, 2026 (weeks 2–4)

Venue	Bets	Win rate	ROI
Novig	41	56%	+10.2%
Best exchange (Novig/ProphetX)	65	62%	+16.4%
Best sportsbook (reference only)	71	59%	+10.5%
Kalshi, spread $\leq 4\phi$	64	66%	+19.0%
Kalshi, resting at the mid	37 filled of 42	62%	+20.5%

Six triggered team-games (Puka Nacua, RJ Harvey, Adonai Mitchell, Jalen Coker, Keenan Allen, Terry McLaurin). Weeks 2–3 overlap the backtest window, so only week 4 is fully out of sample.

Projection

Backtest winners shrink going forward, so plan on **about +5% on Novig** (90% range roughly –2% to +12%).

About 50 more triggered team-games (roughly the rest of this season) confirms or rules out +5% at 2 standard errors.